Boarding: A Shakespearean Tragedy

By Renee Foss

These days it seems that people will almost kill for a first-class seat. I guess it's because conditions are so deplorable in coach. One day I saw two grown adults get into a fight over the last seat in first class. Apparently the computer had made an error (hard to believe, I know) and there were twelve seats but thirteen passengers. Now, we're one of the most civilized, technologically advanced nations in the world, but the behavior of these passengers took me back to the fifteenth century. There is only one word to describe it: "barbaric."

INTRODUCTION

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It was a dark and stormy night. There was thunder, lightning, heavy rain, and a full moon. The three flight attendants prepared the galley and checked the meal count, and as they did so they began to chant:

"Double, double toil and trouble
Fire burn and caldron bubble."

HEAD FLIGHT ATTENDANT: What does thou serve for those who sup in first class?

2ND FLIGHT ATTENDANT: Filet of rattlesnake in the caldron boil and back. Wool of bat wrapped in a leaf.

3RD FLIGHT ATTENDANT: In other words chicken or beef.

A lightning bolt flashed and heavy thunder rumbled.

BOARDING AGENT: A drum, a drum, the passengers doth come.

The first passenger, let us call him Macbeth, boarded.

MACBETH: *(removing cape and hat)* How now, you secret, black, and midnight hags! What is 't you do?

HEAD FLIGHT ATTENDANT: Hail Macbeth, hail to thee. Here is your seat, you have 1B. The last remaining in first class. Now give me you cape and your boarding pass.

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As Mr. Macbeth got situated in his seat, he heard a strange eerie voice that whispered:

"Macbeth, Macbeth, Beware Macduff
Beware the Thane of Crete
Beware Macbeth, she wants your crown
Beware Macbeth, she wants your seat."

It bothered him that no one else seemed to hear the voice, but he had been working hard and he was tired and things weren't going so well with Lady Macbeth back at the castle. The stress was probably getting to him. Maybe he just needed to take it easy and relax he decided, but he would mention this to his doctor on his next visit. At that moment, the thirteenth passenger, Ms. Macduff, entered and the flight attendants assumed the position. In unison they chanted:

"Hail, Hail, Hail Macduff
We see thy drown, we kiss thy feet."

MACDUFF: Enough, enough. There is someone in my seat!"

FLIGHT ATTENDANT: May I see your boarding pass?

Ms. Macduff shoved it in her face and sure enough it was the same seat assignment.

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FLIGHT ATTENDANT: Ah me, toil and trouble, boil and bubble, when seat assignments here are double!

Meanwhile, the passengers took matters into their own hands – which is always a dangerous thing.

MACDUFF: Pray, kind sir, but you're in my throne, where I shall rest till dawn. Remove thyself and get thee gone.

MACBETH: *(fastening his seat belt with no intention of leaving his seat)* I'll not move, I'll not fail. Screw my courage to the sticking place, this is **my** seat and this is **my** space! *(Macduff growls – Macbeth releases his seat belt, stands and brandishes a toenail clipper)* Fie, Fie, I am a frequent flier. / I'll not share this seat with / the likes of you, a common liar.

MACDUFF: *(insulted, rummages in her purse for an eyelash curler which she brandishes)* What care I how much you fly? / I am in the Regal Club and / Have a private room at every hub.

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By now the two of them were standing in the aisle lunging and parrying about the cabin. The flight attendants hid in the galley and the other passengers took cover.

MACBETH: *(jumping onto the seat)* Ha! I won the stock, I am on the board / When I arrive, they call me Lord.

MACDUFF: Lord of what? Pray do tell. / Lord of this? Me thinks it hell.

You have to admit she had a valid point. However, Macbeth's adrenaline was racing and he wasn't about to give into this shrewish hellhound.

MACBETH: *(Shouting)* Nonetheless, that is my seat and it I shall defend. / You, poor wench, will ride in back with all the common men. *(roars like a lion, then issues an evil laugh)*

MACDUFF: *(collapsing in despair)* Ride in coach? I'd rather ride in a boat.

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With that a full-fledged battle ensued. Passengers were taking cover, while the flight attendants continued trying to serve drinks. A beer meant for Macbeth fell off the tray onto Ms. Macduff's brand new Anne Klein suit.

MACBETH: You wench, you fool / You've spilled my beer / I'll write your boss and / Ruin your career.

FLIGHT ATTENDANT: *(furiously scrubbing at the stain on Macduff's suit, she sobs)* Out, out damn spot . . .

HEAD FLIGHT ATTENDANT: A little bit of club soda will take that right out, honey.

With that they threw a can of club soda on Ms. Macduff. Before she could react, they hobbled back to the gallery. At that moment Ms. Macduff pulled a curling iron from her carry-on and thrust it into Macbeth's soft belly.

MACDUFF: *(with a chilling laugh)* I've got you now, size doth not matter.

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Macbeth fell from his first-class seat to the floor. And without missing a beat, Ms. Macduff sat down in seat 1B, for which she had battled valiantly and fairly won. Suddenly, just as she began to relax, Mr. Macbeth, in a surprising comeback, pulled out a golf club from under the seat in front of him and wacked Ms. Macduff in the head. He fell backward as Macduff fell forward on top of him.

HEAD FLIGHT ATTENDANT: *(emerging from the gallery to begin the clean-up process)* Dead, dead, me thinks them dead / Beer has been spilled, body fluid shed. / And yet here lies a seat that is free and / For this chance other beggars outside do / Wait, spewing forth and bitching at the gate. / So bring them in, the next of kin and seal the / Final fate."

At that moment, during the trumpet fanfare, in sauntered a young man. Mr. Hamlet. He was very well dressed, but looked a bit pre-occupied with his own thoughts.

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HAMLET: To be or not to be? That is the question, whether 'tis . . .

HEAD FLIGHT ATTENDANT: No, no no! Excuse me, Mr. Hamlet? Not 2B . . . 1B . . . right over here.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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